as much to social relations as to relations among states. According to this system, for there to be harmony in society and peace in the realm, it was necessary for each constituent to know his place and relate to others according to a strict code of behaviour. There is a verticality in such relations, graduating from the most humble ranks and up to the emperor himself. Any disturbance to this hierarchical principle is a recipe for disorder and conflict. In the 60 years since the establishment of the PRC in 1949, when it was relatively weak, China advocated a multipolar and democratic world order. But as its power has expanded, Chinese scholars and strategists have begun to project multipolarity as an unstable and disorderly state, though official Chinese rhetoric still advocates multipolarity.

At an Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) Regional Forum meeting in Hanoi in 2010, the Chinese Foreign Minister, Yang Jiechi, surprised the gathering by angrily reminding the delegates that ‘China is a big country and you are all small countries and that is just a fact’.

As may have become apparent, the hierarchy principle persists in the way China imagines the world and its place within it.

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It should be noted that through most of its history the main challenge faced by successive Chinese empires was the perennial attacks by fierce nomadic tribes ranging across its northern and western peripheries. Some of these tribes even succeeded in establishing their own rule over the predominantly Han population, and then in turn had to face repeated attacks by other tribal hordes from Central Asia. Over the centuries, these repeated and sometimes successful raids and invasions into the Chinese heartland created a kind of siege mentality, of a mostly civilized and settled central realm with a periphery contested by a variety of less civilized and aggressive ethnicities. These were denoted in the written language with an ‘animal’ radical, suggesting a barbaric character (see Appendix). That is how the notion of a Middle Kingdom came to be entrenched in China’s sense of itself.

In contrast to its northern and western peripheries, China’s maritime